



What should I believe?

If you think about it, our initial question really breaks down into two sub-questions.

When should I form a  
new belief?

When should I discard  
one of my beliefs?

**Positive** rules of belief will tell you  
when you should form a certain  
belief.

If you are in such-and-such  
circumstances, you should  
believe P.

Negative rules of belief will tell you  
when you should not have a certain  
belief.

If you are in such-and-such  
circumstances, you should not  
believe P.

It might at first seem extremely easy to formulate the rules of belief. The following would seem to be plausible candidates, respectively, for positive and negative rules of belief.

If  $P$  is true, you should  
believe  $P$ .

If  $P$  is not true, you should  
not believe  $P$ .

The problem with these rules of belief is not that they are incorrect; the problem is that in many cases they won't be of much practical use, since in many cases we don't know for sure whether the claim in question is true or false. (If we did, there would be no serious question about whether to form the belief.)

TRUTH → BELIEF

NO TRUTH → NO BELIEF

We'll be trying, for the next three classes, to improve upon these two rules by trying to formulate rules of belief which we could actually put to use.

Why would we want to do this? We all face cases where it is not clear what we should believe. In fact, you might think, philosophy is a kind of machine for generating hard cases! Haven't we already seen lots of cases in which there are arguments on both sides of an issue, and where it is hard to tell which argument is better?

Here is a hard case of interest:

## The Believer

I've always believed that there is a God. I never really thought about what my evidence is for this claim. But now I wonder whether I have good reason for my beliefs. Some of the arguments for God's existence sound good, but all face objections that I am not sure how to answer. Still, I continue to believe that God exists.

It is genuinely hard to know what to do in this kind of situation. And it is hard to see how to figure it out other than by trying to figure out what the rules of belief are.

Today we're going to focus on the question,

When should I discard  
one of my beliefs?

This is a question which most people face at some point in their lives. Often, people face it in an especially sharp way at exactly the age you are now. Going to college, where you encounter new ideas and new people, is a natural time to wonder whether you still really accept the views that you used to believe.

“Some years ago I was struck by the large number of falsehoods which I had accepted as true in my childhood, and by the highly doubtful nature of the whole edifice that I had subsequently based on them. I realized that it was necessary, once in the course of my life, to demolish everything completely and start again right from the foundations if I wanted to establish anything at all ... that was stable and likely to last.”

Descartes gave a famous statement of this idea:

Your system of beliefs is like a web. Once you form a new belief, that belief typically combines with your other beliefs to give you yet more beliefs. So forming even one belief which you should not form is likely to lead to a whole series of mistakes.

Descartes' thought is that the only way to fix this situation is to re-examine your beliefs once you are an adult, and see if there are any that you should discard.



What should I believe?

if you think about it, our initial question really breaks down into two sub-

questions.



When should I form a  
new belief?

When should I discard  
one of my beliefs?

when you should form a certain

berief.

Positive rules of belief will tell you









berief.

when you should not have a certain

Negative rules will tell you









and negative rules of belief.

It might at first seem extremely easy to formulate the rules of belief. The

following would seem to be plausible candidates, respectively, for positive



If  $P$  is true, you should  
believe  $P$ .



If  $P$  is not true, you should  
not believe  $P$ .

The problem with these rules of belief is not that they are incorrect; the

the belie.f.)

many cases we don't know for sure whether the claim in question is true or

problem is that in many cases they won't be of much practical use, since in

false. (If we did, there would be no serious question about whether to form



TRUTH → BELIEF



NO TRUTH  $\rightarrow$  NO BELIEF

We'll be trying, for the next three classes, to improve upon these two rules

by trying to formulate rules of belief which we could actually put to use.

Why would we want to do this? Well, face cases where it is not clear

hard to tell which argument is better?

in which there are arguments on both sides of an issue, and where it is

what we should believe. In fact, you might think, philosophy is a kind of



machine for generating hardware! Haven't yet already seen lots of cases



## The Believer

I've always believed that there is a God. I never really thought about what my evidence is for this claim. But now I wonder whether I have good reason for my beliefs. Some of the arguments for God's existence sound good, but all face objections that I am not sure how to answer. Still, I continue to believe that God exists.

It is genuinely hard to know what to do in this kind of situation. And

but what the rules of belief are.

it is hard to see how to figure it out other than by trying to figure

When should I discard  
one of my beliefs?

time to wonder whether you still really accept the views that you used to

Going to college, where you encounter new ideas and new people, is a natural

This is a question which most people face at some point in their lives. Often,

people face it in an especially sharp way at exactly the age you are now.

bedrive.





stair again right from the foundation if I wanted to

Realized that it was necessary, once in the course

of my life, to deny I wish every thing I could let my and

childhood, and by the highly influential nature

'Some years ago I was struck by the large number of

east abolish anything at all that was stable and

1111y to 11ast. ; ;

failures which I had accepted as true in my

while I did not have any basis for that.

typically combines with your other beliefs to give you yet more beliefs. So

whole series of mistakes.

Your system of beliefs is like a web. Once you form a new belief, that belief

forming even one belief which you should not form is likely to lead to a

you're beliefs once you're an adult, and see if there are any that you should

De Santis' thought is that the only way to fix this situation is to re-examine

discard.

you're beliefs once you're an adult, and see if there are any that you should

Desdantes' thought is that the only way to fix this situation is to re-examine

discard.